

The AJ&Smart Design Sprint Checklist

Everything you need to know to run your own sprints, successfully.

This document is the “source file” for running AJ&Smart’s version of the Design Sprint. We have made so many tweaks, changes and additions to the process that we needed to define the “gold standard” of our process so we have a base we can actually experiment and improve on (and go back to if experiments fail!), onboard new employees with and also keep the quality of the process high. What you get here is the **exact same document** we use internally, but even better: We have added some clarifications to turn this into a useful tool for your own Sprints, even if you have never run a Sprint before!

One thing we should mention, though: This document is not intended to teach you how the process works specifically. We didn’t want to recreate the videos in written form, we want this to be a real tool for facilitators. That’s why we aren’t going to explain each exercise in detail – this is what the course and training is for.

Sprint Preflight Checklist

This is what needs to happen before the Sprint

The success of a sprint doesn't just depend on great facilitation, an amazing prototype or a well-planned user test. Especially when you run your first Sprint, the many moving parts of the process itself can feel overwhelming. One thing we have found out is that you can make your own job much, much easier with a little bit of prep work.

When?	What?
As soon as you have confirmation the sprint is happening	You need to confirm Sprint details. ☐ Which team/client are you doing the Sprint with? ☐ What is the topic (even roughly)? ☐ When and where is it taking place (you need a room)? ☐ Who will supply/organize the needed materials and catering? ☐ Who takes part in the sprint? ☐ Who's the decider? It must be 100% clear that the decider joins for the entire duration of the workshop. We are assuming that it's clear who's building the prototype (i.e., you or someone on your team is responsible). If you can't or don't want to be responsible for this, make sure that there's a designer joining from their side.
2 weeks before sprint	You should schedule an informal call with the Project Owner. This isn't necessarily the decider, it's basically the one person who has a stake in the sprint outcome and has a strong interest that it runs as smoothly as possible. Get additional details from them: ☐ Prepare a rough draft of the map and run it by them. This will give you a headstart in the map exercise during the Sprint week. Just assume a lot of things and get their help to fill in the blanks! ☐ Quiz them about possible target groups. Is it B2C or B2B? Is it about a product they want to sell or an internal process? This will allow you to prepare user test recruiting early. ☐ Try to find out what their REAL expectations are. Is it to validate a business case? Is it to create a kickass-looking prototype to unlock a budget? Is it to generate lots of ideas?

	Essentially, what you want to find out is what they need to impress their superiors.
1 full week before the Sprint	Set up a Basecamp for the Sprint and invite all participants (as clients), and send them a little introduction as a welcome message. Here's what needs to be in the message: ❑ Tell them you are looking forward to the Sprint! Try to get them excited! Be appreciative of them joining the Sprint. ❑ Where and when to come. This sounds obvious, but make this as clear as possible. Also tell them very clearly when the workshop kicks off. ❑ Manage their expectations! Most people hate being thrown into uncertain or unclear situations. Give them a rough breakdown of what's going to happen, that it will be a busy day but fun. ❑ Introduce the "No Device Rule". This primes them that they aren't going to be able to answer calls and emails instantly and allows them to prepare autoresponders and reschedule calls. ❑ Thank them for joining the Sprint! Make them feel valued. The Sprint probably disrupted their work week and plans, so it doesn't hurt to acknowledge this. ❑ Offer to answer their questions if they have any! You are their host. Try to be as helpful as possible.
1 full week before the Sprint	If you bring your own team, add your team members to the Basecamp as well. ❑ Keep your team and their team separate. Don't add them to the client side, this allows you to have your own internal discussions. ❑ Share all the collected info about the Sprint with them so they have context. ❑ Assigns roles. Make sure people understand what they need to do during the workshop. It's a huge help if you can share the responsibilities and allows you to focus on the facilitation.
Friday before Sprint	❑ Do a quick Lightning Demo research session so you have relevant examples to show on Monday! It saves you time on Monday you can use to prepare other exercises.

Roles and Responsibilities

This is what needs to happen before the Sprint

These are the roles in a Sprint team. At AJ&Smart, each team member takes on multiple roles at the same time (some roles work best if combined with other roles). **Obviously, being able to share the responsibility makes things easier, but it's also possible to run a Sprint on your own (with a little bit of additional prep work).** We have run Sprints with anything from 4 people on our side to just 1 – it always worked out. For us, the “goldilocks” team-size is 2 people handling the workshop part (1 main facilitator, 1 supporter/runner). A smaller team can actually make things easier, since you don't need to “direct” or micromanage as many people, and there are no uncertainties about who's responsible for what.

Role	Responsibility
Sprint Lead (entire sprint)	Responsible for Sprint outcome and quality. Needs to make sure room is properly set up and that everything runs smoothly.
Sprint Host (during workshop)	Responsible for client well-being and hospitality. Needs to make sure clients get coffee, tea, fresh water, snack and regular breaks.
Facilitation Part 1 (Monday morning until noon)	Moderation and facilitation of these exercises: ☐ Onboarding ☐ HMW exercise ☐ Long-Term Goal ☐ Sprint Questions ☐ Map Exercise This is a difficult part of the workshop. Participants are still warming up and might be skeptical, and the exercises might seem a bit random to them (= they don't know the endpoint of the journey!). They will also try to open up discussion which the facilitator needs to gently steer and shut down if they are unproductive. Having good social skills helps a lot here, but you can make up for it if you know the process by heart, and having product design/product strategy experience also helps a lot.
Facilitation Part 2 (Monday noon until evening)	Moderation and facilitation of these exercises: ☐ Lightning Demos ☐ Note-Taking

	☐ Doodling ☐ Crazy 8s ☐ Three-Part Concept. This is pretty easy! Participants should have gotten into the groove by now. The process itself is easy to facilitate, it's almost like reading off a script, and there's no need for discussions.
Facilitation Part 3 (Tuesday morning until noon)	Moderation and facilitation of these exercises: ☐ Art Gallery ☐ Presentations ☐ Straw Poll ☐ Decider Vote ☐ User Testing Flow This is also easy!
Facilitation Part 4 (Tuesday noon until evening)	Moderation and facilitation of these exercises: ☐ Storyboard ☐ Wrap-up The storyboard is the hardest part of the workshop. Doing this as a facilitation team helps – one moderator and one artist. Having product design / product strategy knowledge helps a lot.
Music	Whoever facilitates should be in charge of the workshop music.
Runner	A person other than the facilitator who can prepare supplies in advance, replenish water and snacks, etc. This role is optional, but will make the facilitation a lot easier. If you are running a sprint alone, you should try to prepare as much of the supplies in advance as possible (i.e. cutting dots).
Prototyper	Responsible for getting Prototype done in time.
Recruiter	Responsible for getting testers for Thursday and scheduling.
Interviewer	Responsible for running interviews.
Notetaker	Responsible for note-taking during interviews.
Basecamp Updates	Posts on Tuesday and Wednesday. <i>And regular updates on Thursday during Interviews if unforeseen scheduling situations/dropouts happen</i>

Photographer	Responsible that there are photos of every part of the Sprint for documentation.
Final Basecamp Update	Posts the final report on Thursday. This is easier if it's done as a team.

Materials

This is what you need for the first two Sprint days.

In general, you should make sure that materials and supplies are easily and abundantly available to all participants. The process itself is complicated enough, you don't want to skimp on materials and then run out during the workshop or have to start rationing.

Material	How many?
☐ Rectangular Post-Its (yellow)	Min. 1 stack per participant. Doesn't hurt to have more.
☐ Square Post-Its (yellow)	Min. 1 stack per participant.
☐ Square Post-Its (blue or pink)	Min. 1 stack per participant.
☐ Red dot stickers, 8mm diameter.	Lots! Min. 1 full sheet per participant. To be on the safe side, rather get too many than too few.
☐ Green or red dot stickers, 18mm diameter.	1-2 sheets.
☐ Sharpies	At least 1 per participant, but get some as reserve.
☐ Masking tape	1 roll per 3 participants.
☐ Scissors	1 per 3 participants.
☐ Plain white printer paper	1 full pack of printing paper (~500 pages). You won't use the entire pack but it's good to have a reserve.

❑ Time Timer	1 is sufficient. Double check if it works, it's annoying if you bring one but the battery is dead. We like Time Timers because they are big enough for everyone to see, but alternatives are also fine.
❑ Camera	1 for documentation. A bulky DSLR isn't necessary, a point and shoot is the better choice. Phone is also fine in a pinch, but it's better to avoid using your phone.
❑ Bluetooth speaker	1 to play workshop music from. If you need workshop music, just use this playlist .
❑ Magic Paper	1 roll
❑ Whiteboards	1 or 2. Can be replaced by magic paper if necessary.
❑ Whiteboard markers (black, green, red)	1 each.
❑ Snacks and beverages	Nuts are a good choice, also sliced fruits. Water (fizzy and flat), coffee and tea (avoid sugary snacks and beverages)

The Sprint Week

A play-by-play of the first week.

This is an outline of the process without much exposition and explanation – if you need details for the exercises, just watch the videos (otherwise this would get too cluttered).

Don't worry if some things take longer than the durations. These are guidelines! Depending on the number of participants, some exercises might be longer or shorter. One helpful rule of thumb: To keep the momentum up, rather time exercises a bit too short than too long. This keeps the momentum up and you can still give people extra time if necessary.

Day 1: Monday

Pregame

9:15	Prepare the room Put stacks of rectangular post-its, sharpies, paper on the table so everyone can easily reach them. Put glasses on the table	30 min
9:45	Greet participants When the participants arrive, make them feel comfortable. Offer them coffee and snacks.	Until 10:10
10:10	Shepherd participants to the sprint room	5 min

Part 1 - Onboarding and defining the challenge.

10:15	Welcome and 360 introductions Thank them again for coming. Then ask them to write on rectangular post-its: My name is..., My role is..., My wish for this sprint is.... Then, let everyone read out their intro.	10 min
10:30	Intro presentation Who you are. What Sprints are. Ground Rules. What to expect.	15 min
10:40	Introduce the Decider Ideally the Decider has been pre-defined during the preparation. Just explain quickly that the Decider is the tie-breaker.	5 min
10:45	Expert interview	30 min

	HMWs on rectangular post-its	
11:15	HMW Voting Decider gets 4 dots, everyone else 2	10 min
11:25	<i>Optional: coffee break</i>	10 min
11:35	Long Term Goal Brainstorm Together alone, group creates individual LTGs, one per person. Ideally with KPIs in goals (“In 2 years, we have X amount of users”)	5 min
11:40	LTG presentations (1 min per team member)	10 min
11:50	The Decider picks one LTG Should only pick one, but can also merge two.	5 min
11:55	Can We...? Brainstorm Together alone, group creates pessimistic “Can We...” questions, individually.	5 min
12:00	Can We...? presentation 1 min per team member. Just read them aloud, stick them to the wall. Next.	10 min
12:10	Can We...? Voting Decider doesn’t vote, everyone else gets 2 dots.	5 min
12:15	Decider picks Top Can We question.	5 min
12:20	Create Sprint Questions from Top 3 Can We’s.	5 min
12:25	Map Then, add HMWs to map.	20 min
12:45	Circle target on map.	5 min

Lunch

12:50	Lunch If you can, let them have lunch outside the Sprint room so they can clear their minds. They shouldn’t break up and go out for lunch, you need to provide the catering onsite.	40 min
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Part 2 – Creating solutions

13:30	Lightning Demos Explicitly allow them to use their devices for this. Max. 3 per person.	10 min
13:40	Demo presentations One person has to take notes on rectangular post-its and stick them up to the wall.	20 min
14:00	Note-taking Reassure them that they don't need creativity and can just start by copying the artifacts that already exist. When the time is up, you can let this exercise flow into doodling ("I noticed some of you already started sketching..."). Remind them of the goal, target and sprint questions.	15 min
14:15	Doodling Be aware of the mood of the participants. If you notice somebody struggling or being stuck, reassure them that even drawing boxes is fine for now.	20 min
14:35	Crazy 8s 1 minute per cell. This is the exercise that needs most explanations. Also mention that it's fine to just use this as a warm-up.	10 min
14:45	Coffee Break And fresh air. Bring bean bags.	15 min
15:00	3-part-sketching Remind them: Clear handwriting. Add notes. Give it a name.	45 min

Wrap-up – End of Day 1

15:45	Hang up concepts Assist clients if they need help. Hang the concepts front facing the wall.	5 min
15:50	Bring beer and offer soft drink alternatives	10 min
16:00	Next steps Congratulate them! What will happen tomorrow? What will happen in the rest of the week?	10 min

Day 2: Tuesday

Pregame

9:15	Prepare the room Clean the room. Spread the concepts out nicely (don't bunch them up). Put refreshments on the table.	30 min
9:45	Greet clients Ask if they want coffee.	Until 10:10
10:10	Shepherd clients to sprint room	5 min

Part 3 – Decide on a solution

10:15	Welcome back! Explain next step, while helpers reveal concepts.	10 min
10:25	Art Gallery Half dot sheet per person	20 min
10:45	Concept presentations Heat Map Presentations and Note Taking.	15 min
11:00	Straw Poll 1 big dot per Person, ask them to put initials on them and to pick their winner based on Sprint Questions.	10 min
11:10	Decider vote 2 Big Dots with a star. Can be combined with a coffee break if they need to discuss. When it's done, take a moment and tell them: Good Job!	15 min
11:25	User Test Flow Create 123/ABC wall matrix, then tell them to use 6 post-its to create the rough flow. Don't put it up yet but hold on to them.	10 min
11:35	User Test Flow presentations Participants go to the 123/ABC wall and present their flow quickly.	10 min
11:45	User Test Flow voting 1 dot per person, goes on the ABCs.	10 min

11:55	Decider vote 2 decider dots. Pick one of the ABCs and a wildcard.	5 min
12:00	Create combined User Test Flow Ca. 8 post-its.	10 min

Lunch

12:15	Lunch	60 min
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Part 4 – Storyboard

13:15	Coffee orders In the meantime, create 10 Storyboard panels.	10 min
13:25	Storyboard 1st pass Align the chosen User Test Flow post-its into the panels. Walkthrough rough story again.	10 min
13:35	Storyboard 2nd pass Use sketches from concepts to fill in blanks. Start asking about target group (testers).	45 min
14:20	Coffee break And fresh air.	15 min
14:35	Storyboard 3rd pass Fill in Details. Also be careful to fill in in-between states.	45 min
15:20	Walkthrough of finished Storyboard Mark high priority screens (“If we can’t finish everything, which screens HAVE to be in?”)	10 min
15:30	Hand out Goodie Bags One for each participant. Tell them we would love to hear if they had a chance to try some exercises themselves.	5 min

User Recruiting

This can happen in parallel to the storyboarding. Ideally, you have done this even sooner (Monday), but sometimes it's just not possible. By now you should know who the target group is and be able to target the Facebook ads (or Craigslist, or Instagram ads...).

13:15	Set up a typeform to qualify leads You need to ask for their name, email, for their phone number (important!) – and whatever else you need as qualifiers (age, gender, profession, location...). Also ask them if they have a working computer and webcam if the test is remote. You'll get a lot of random signups, so being able to filter will make your life a lot easier on Wednesday!	30 min
13:45	Write recruiting ad Include a link to to the typeform. Don't be too specific what you are testing.	15 min
14:00	Post the ad Once it's out, you just wait for people to do the typeform.	5 min

Wrap-up – End of Day 2

15:30	Check off sprint agreements “We set a goal, we set questions, we created a storyboard...” – make sure they know that from now on they won't be able to change directions.	10 min
15:40	Feedback and Next steps “I liked, A success was, I wish” exercise. Then: What will happen tomorrow? What will happen in the rest of the week?	10 min
15:50	Drinks & Goodbyes	25 min
16:15	Post first Basecamp update Give them a breakdown of what happened the last 2 days, the decisions that came out of it and what will happen next!	15 min

Day 3: Wednesday

This is relevant if you are responsible for the prototyping. If you are a consultant or facilitator, maybe you won't be deeply involved in this part, but you should still own the responsibility of getting the prototype done in time. Keep in mind that the test has to happen on Thursday. **The priority is to get the prototype to a state which enables you to get answers to the Sprint questions!** Visual polish, branding, color scheme, **even usability** are secondary to this. Think about it this way: The prototype is like a pitchdeck. It should clearly bring the ideas you want to test across, and it should look real enough so people can give you qualified feedback. If you get this done early and there's time to polish, great. But don't waste time on making 15 different versions of the logo and then freak out in the afternoon because time is running out.

Pregame

9:45	Team Huddle Confirm who is responsible for what task. Review Storyboard. Mark high priority screens if this didn't happen before. Check if there is anything you can recycle from previous prototypes.	10 min
9:55	Morning update Simple, short morning Basecamp update to client and tell them what will happen today. Create Marvel (or Invision, or whatever tool you use) project now, send link to whoever does the Basecamp update.	5 min

Prototyping

10:00	Prototyping 1st pass Work on High Priority Screens first	180 min
12:30	Order/organize lunch Sprint Host: Ask Prototypers if they want lunch from the outside, or order something for them.	30 min
13:00	Lunch break Take 30 minutes away from the computer and get fresh air.	30 min
13:30	1st Check-in	15 min

	What's the status. Any trouble? Anything unclear? What needs to change?	
13:45	Prototyping 2nd pass Finish High Priority Screens, then fill up as much as possible.	195 min
17:00	2nd Check-in What's the status. Don't create new screens after this one, clean-up only!	15 min
17:15	Prototyping 3rd pass Mopping up and prototype creation. The day should end at 19:00 latest! If it's not done in time, it needs to be addressed in the retrospective on Friday.	105 min

User test prep and recruiting

10:00	Recruiting and confirming bookings Check the typeform results. Get their phone no. and confirm directly with them. This works best to avoid no-shows. Once a tester confirmed, send them instructions for Thursday (time slots, if there's a remote hangout, etc.). You need 5 confirmed bookings and should get 2 alternates as well.	All day
10:00	Set up livestream or recording (optional) If the sprint team can't join for the testing day, it's a good idea to set up a livestream or record the tests, so they can watch them later (this is a valuable artifact for most teams, even if they never watch it again).	All day
13:00	Lunch break Take 30 minutes away from the computer and get fresh air.	30 min
18:00	Evening Basecamp update Send out Basecamp Update, including test schedule, photos, link to prototype and link for live stream (if you do one).	15 min
18:15	Prepare Testing Board Name of tester, time of test, topics to test.	15 min

Day 4: Thursday

Pregame

9:30	Team Huddle Confirm who does what. Review Prototype. Set up live stream. Get room ready. Get snacks and water, you'll be locked in that room for several hours.	10 min
9:40	Morning update Simple, short morning Basecamp update to team to tell them tests are about to start.	5 min

Testing

10:00	First Round Interviews Ideally finishing at 4pm (Latest). 1 Interviewer plus 1 Notetaker.	Ca. 3 h
11:00	Optional Prototype tweaks Fix any obvious quick fixes after the first interview.	30 min
14:00	Second Round Interviews If possible, Notetaker takes Interviewer role, while Interviewer starts writing the Basecamp update.	Ca. 2 h

Basecamp Report

16:00	Braindump Together alone, Interviewer and Note-taker individually write down big trends from the interviews and compare (quick points).	10 min
17:30	Finish update Notetaker adds in all the Points taken (wall of feedback), Sprint lead writes Sprint Question Answers, plus 3-5 recommendations.	60 min

Iteration Sprint Week

A play-by-play of the second Sprint week.

This is an outline of the process without much exposition and explanation – if you need details for the exercises, just watch the videos (otherwise this would get too cluttered). In an iteration week, Monday is the only workshop day. Monday is a condensed version of the first two days of the first week.

Day 1: Monday

Pregame

9:10	Prepare the room Everyone should have read the full report from week 1. What are the top recommendations, what didn't work, what went well?	30 min
9:45	Onboard clients Whenever the first client arrives, give them slippers, ask if they want coffee, let them order lunch on the iPad.	Until 10:10
10:10	Shepherd clients to sprint room	5 min

Part 1 – Recap and deciding on Top 3 problems to solve

10:15	Welcome back! Give them a quick recap of last week and the tests.	15 min
10:30	Sail Boat What worked, what didn't? Notetaker should capture these and put them on magic paper (positives on the top, negatives at the bottom)	15 min
10:45	Vote on problems 3 dots per person, only vote on negatives. Decider doesn't vote.	5 min
10:50	Decider picks Top 3 problems 3 big green dots.	10 min
11:00	Turn Top 3 problems into “Can We” Questions Add them to the Sprint Questions.	10 min

11:10	Optional: coffee break	10-15 min
11:25	Notetaking Remind them of the Can We's for this week. They should also write down the LTG and the original Sprint Questions.	15 min
11:40	Doodling You can go into doodling straight from the notetaking, just reset the timer. They can either doodle something for all Can We's or just for one.	15 min
11:55	Crazy 8s 1 minute per cell.	10 min
12:05	3-part-sketching Participants can sketch solution for either of the Top 3 problems (or all, if they can). Remind them: clear handwriting. Add notes. Give it a name.	45 min

Lunch

12:50	Lunch In common area. Sprint Host: Make sure that client names are on food. Put plates on the table as well	45 min
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Part 2 – Deciding on solutions to Top 3 problems

13:30	Art Gallery Half dot sheet per person	20 min
13:50	Concept presentations Heat Map Presentations and Note Taking.	20 min
14:10	Straw Poll 1 big dot per Person, ask them to put initials on them and to pick their winner based on Sprint Questions.	5 min
14:15	Decider vote 3 Big Dots with a star (1 per HMW). When it's done, take a moment and tell them: Good Job!	10 min
14:25	Optional: coffee break	10-15

	In the meantime, recreate the original test flow (use the original post-its if you have them) and space them out, and create a 123/ABC matrix.	min
14:40	Expanded User Test Flow Participants can now create up to 3 <i>additional post-its</i> that can be added to any part of the original test flow.	10 min
14:50	User Test Flow presentations Participants go to the 123/ABC matrix and present their additions quickly.	10 min
15:00	User Test Flow voting 1 dot per person, goes on the ABCs.	10 min
15:10	Decider vote 2 decider dots. Pick two of the ABCs. It's possible to combine some of them (but don't overdo it).	5 min
15:15	Create combined User Test Flow Ca. 8 post-its.	10 min

Wrap-up

15:25	Good job! High fives.	5 min
15:30	Bring the beer and offer soft drink alternatives	10 min
15:40	Next steps: What will happen tomorrow? What will happen in the rest of the week?	10 min

Day 4: Thursday

Pregame

9:30	Team Huddle Confirm who does what. Review Prototype. Set up live stream. Get room ready. Get snacks and water.	10 min
9:40	Morning update Simple, short morning Basecamp update to client and tell them tests are about to start.	5 min

Testing

10:00	First Round Interviews Ideally finishing at 4pm (Latest). 1 Interviewer plus 1 Notetaker.	Ca. 3 h
11:00	Optional Prototype tweaks Fix any obvious quick fixes after the first interview.	30 min
14:00	Second Round Interviews If possible, Notetaker takes Interviewer role, while Interviewer starts writing the Basecamp update.	Ca. 2 h

Basecamp Report

16:00	Braindump Together alone, Interviewer and Note-taker individually write down big trends from the interviews and compare (quick points).	10 min
	Effort/Impact (if applicable)	
17:30	Finish update	60 min

Notetaker adds in all the Points taken (wall of feedback), Sprint lead writes Sprint Question Answers, plus 3-5 recommendations. Our last recommendation should always be a Lightning Decisions Jam to internally and prioritse next steps (include link to Video and article on LDJ)	
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